UPFRONT

HEALTH WATCH: ROBOTIC TELE SURGERIES *PG 11*

GRAPHIC: THE NEW CLIMATE NORMAL *PG 12*



CAUGHT IN A BIND
Nikhil Gupta in US custody

X/DEA New York

▶ PANNUN MURDER CONSPIRACY

FALLOUT OF A FAILED PLOT

Indian national Nikhil Gupta's guilty plea in the assassination plot of a US-based Sikh dissident may limit the heat on New Delhi, though it may become a factor in the Indo-US bilateral talks

By PRADIP R. SAGAR

ON FEBRUARY 13, NIKHIL GUPTA, A 54-YEAR-OLD INDIAN national, pleaded guilty in a United States federal court in New York to charges of murder-for-hire, conspiracy to commit murder-for-hire, and conspiracy to commit money laundering. The charges relate to an alleged 2023 plot to assassinate Gurpatwant Singh Pannun, a US citizen and prominent advocate of the Khalistan separatist movement. According to prosecutors, Gupta coordinated the scheme at the direction of an Indian government employee identified in court documents as 'CC-1', widely reported to be Vikash Yadav, an Indian intelligence operative. The alleged plot collapsed when the supposed hitman turned out to be a confidential US informant, ultimately leading to Gupta's arrest in the Czech Republic in 2023 and his extradition to the US in 2024.

Pannun serves as general counsel for 'Sikhs for Justice', a North America-based organisation that has been declared unlawful in India. India's ministry of home affairs has also designated Pannun as a terrorist. "Nikhil Gupta plotted to assassinate a US citizen in New York City," said US attorney Jay Clayton. "He thought that from outside this country, he could kill someone in it without consequence, simply for exercising their American right to free speech. But he was wrong, and he will face justice. Our message to all nefarious foreign actors should be clear: steer clear of the US and our people."

FBI assistant director James C. Barnacle Jr was a bit more direct in his comments. "At the direction and coordination of an Indian government employee, Nikhil Gupta plotted to assassinate a US citizen on American soil, facilitating a foreign adversary's unlawful effort to silence a vocal critic of the Indian government," he said.

While New Delhi has categorically denied any official involvement, describing such allegations as baseless and contrary to state policy, it has set up a high-level